SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #26 · JOB LOSS AND SETBACKS

“I'm a failure because I lost my job.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Losing a job can feel personal even when it is not. Layoffs, closures, health problems, and changes in an industry happen to capable people. Yet many of us learned that success means staying employed and that anything else is failure. Shame often arrives faster than the facts, especially if we tied our identity to the job or worry about what family will say.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not treat a fall as the end of a person. Proverbs says that though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up. Micah says, “Though I have fallen, I will arise; though I sit in darkness, the LORD will be my light.” The psalmist says the Lord is near to the brokenhearted. Falling is part of life, and what makes someone a failure in God’s eyes is not what happened to them but whether they stay down. God stays close in the meantime.

> *“For though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up; but the wicked stumble in bad times”* (Proverbs 24:16).

Also see

> “Do not gloat over me, my enemy! Though I have fallen, I will arise; though I sit in darkness, the LORD will be my light” (Micah 7:8).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever” (Psalm 73:26).

> “Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead” (Philippians 3:13).

Common self-statements

- If I were better, I would still have my job.
- I let everyone down.
- This proves I was never good enough.
- I am a failure.
- Everyone else holds on to their jobs.
- I should have seen it coming.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself “a failure” instead of describing an event.
- Personalization: Taking blame for decisions made by the company or the economy.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing myself as either successful or a failure.
- Hindsight bias: Believing I should have known what I could not have known.

Challenging questions

- What actually led to the job loss, and which parts were outside my control?
- What would I tell a friend who lost a job in the same way?

- What skills and accomplishments do I still have?
- Where did I learn that losing a job means failing?
- What does God say about people who fall?
- What is one step I can take to get back up?

Truth summary

> Losing a job is something that happened to me, not what I am. I may have things to learn, and some parts may have been outside my control. God is near to me in this season, and I can get up and take the next step.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Occupation/Job/Work
- Hardship
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Strength

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Unemployment
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Greater — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm a failure because I lost my job"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm a failure because I lost my job." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What actually happened?
- ☐ What was outside my control?
- ☐ What would I say to a friend?
- ☐ What is still true about me?
- ☐ Who can I talk with?
- ☐ What is one step this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ A job loss is an event, not an identity.
- ☐ I can fall and still get up.
- ☐ God is near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ My skills and character remain.
- ☐ I can learn without condemning myself.
- ☐ I do not have to face this alone.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Proverbs 24:16**
  "For though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up; but the wicked stumble in bad times."
- ☐ **Micah 7:8**
  "Do not gloat over me, my enemy! Though I have fallen, I will arise; though I sit in darkness, the LORD will be my light."
- ☐ **Psalm 34:18**
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Facts, not verdicts: Each day, write one fact about what happened and one thing about yourself that is still true.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Proverbs 24:16 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can fall and still get up, because the Lord is near.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Occupation/Job/Work" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Separate facts from verdicts. Write what happened on one side and what you tell yourself about it on the other.
- ☐ List your strengths. Write five skills or accomplishments that did not disappear with the job.
- ☐ Tell a trusted person. Share the whole story and ask for their view.
- ☐ Take one step. Update a resume, contact a former coworker, or schedule a conversation.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm a failure because I lost my job": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step back up
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm a failure because I lost my job.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You are near to the brokenhearted. I feel the sting of this loss. Lift me up, remind me who I am in You, and show me the next step. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #27 · JOB LOSS AND SETBACKS

"I'll never recover from this."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

After a major loss, the future can look closed. Savings shrink, applications go unanswered, and each week of waiting makes the fear grow. If we have seen someone in our family never recover from a setback, we may assume the same will happen to us. Exhaustion and discouragement make "never" sound like a fact.

What Scripture teaches

The psalmist says that weeping may stay the night, but joy comes in the morning. Those who sow in tears will reap with shouts of joy. God says, "Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert." Job's story ended in restoration. These verses do not promise a timetable or a return to what was, but they say that the night has an end and that God works in the desert.

> *"For His anger is fleeting, but His favor lasts a lifetime. Weeping may stay the night, but joy comes in the morning"* (Psalm 30:5).

Also see

> "Those who sow in tears will reap with shouts of joy" (Psalm 126:5).

> "Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert" (Isaiah 43:19).

> "After Job had prayed for his friends, the LORD restored his prosperity and doubled his former possessions" (Job 42:10).

> "And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose" (Romans 8:28).

Common self-statements

- This is the end of my career.
- I will never be financially stable again.
- Things will never go back to normal.
- It is too late for me to start over.
- Nothing I try works.
- This is how my life will be from now on.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that nothing will improve.
- Catastrophizing: Treating a hard season as permanent ruin.
- Mental filter: Focusing on the closed doors and missing the open ones.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling hopeless and concluding that the situation is hopeless.

Challenging questions

- When have I been through a hard stretch before and come out the other side?

- What small signs of movement do I see, even if slow?
- Who has recovered from something similar, and how?
- What is the difference between “this is hard” and “this is forever”?
- What do I need in this season, such as rest, support, or practical help?
- What is the smallest step I can take today?

Truth summary

> “Never” is a feeling, not a fact. Hard seasons can be long, but they end. God works in deserts and brings morning after the night. I can take small steps, accept help, and trust that recovery can come.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Hopeless
- Hardship
- Troubles
- Trust
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Unemployment

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ’s resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God’s renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God’s steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'll never recover from this"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'll never recover from this." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When have I recovered before?
- ☐ What small progress do I see?
- ☐ Who has come through something similar?
- ☐ What do I need right now?
- ☐ What is the smallest step today?
- ☐ Where am I saying "never"?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Joy comes in the morning.
- ☐ "Never" is a prediction, not a fact.
- ☐ God makes a way in the wilderness.
- ☐ Recovery can be slow and still real.
- ☐ I have come through hard times before.
- ☐ Small steps count.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 30:5
  "For His anger is fleeting, but His favor lasts a lifetime. Weeping may stay the night, but joy comes in the morning."
- ☐ Psalm 126:5
  "Those who sow in tears will reap with shouts of joy."
- ☐ Isaiah 43:19
  "Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Signs of movement: Each week, write one small sign of progress, such as a call returned or a skill refreshed.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 30:5 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Weeping may stay the night, but joy comes in the morning.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Hopeless" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

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- ☐ List past recoveries. Write three hard times you came through and what helped.
- ☐ Mark small wins. Keep a list of each step taken, even tiny ones.
- ☐ Ask for support. Tell one person how heavy this is and ask for encouragement or a lead.
- ☐ Pray with Psalm 30:5. Read it slowly and tell God where you cannot see the morning yet.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'll never recover from this": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A sign of recovery
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'll never recover from this.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, the night feels long. Remind me that joy comes in the morning and that You make a way in the wilderness. Give me strength for today and hope for tomorrow. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #28 · JOB LOSS AND SETBACKS

"Others must think I'm useless."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

After a setback, we often imagine what other people are saying. A family member's silence, a former coworker's awkward pause, or a friend's "So what are you doing now?" can feel like judgment. If we grew up in a family where reputation mattered, the fear of being seen as a failure can be stronger than the loss itself.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture warns that the fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the Lord is set securely on high. Paul asks, "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?" and says that we are approved by God, who examines our hearts. The psalmist says, "The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?" This is not a call to ignore people. It is an invitation to anchor our worth in God's view, which is steadier than anyone's opinion.

> *"Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ"* (Galatians 1:10).

Also see

> "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high" (Proverbs 29:25).

> "The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?" (Psalm 118:6).

> "Instead, we speak as those approved by God to be entrusted with the gospel, not in order to please men but God, who examines our hearts" (1 Thessalonians 2:4).

> "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:14).

Common self-statements

- Everyone thinks I am a failure.
- People are talking about me.
- They are being polite, but they pity me.
- I cannot face anyone I know.
- I have lost everyone's respect.
- They are better than me now.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know what others think.
- Spotlight effect: Believing everyone is focused on my situation.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed and concluding that people look down on me.
- Personalization: Reading neutral comments as judgment.

Challenging questions

- What have people actually said to me, as opposed to what I imagine?
- Who has treated me with kindness since this happened?

- Would I think a friend was useless in my situation?
- Whose approval matters most to me, and why?
- What does God say about my worth?
- What would help me face people with less shame?

Truth summary

> I cannot read other people's minds, and most people are more focused on their own lives than on mine. God's view of me has not changed. I can trust Him instead of fearing others' opinions and let kind people help.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Fear
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Trust
- Pride

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Unemployment

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Others must think I'm useless"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Others must think I'm useless." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What have people actually said?
- ☐ Who has been kind to me?
- ☐ What would I think of a friend in my place?
- ☐ Whose approval do I most want?
- ☐ What does God think of me?
- ☐ What simple answer can I prepare?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I do not know what others think.
- ☐ The fear of man is a snare.
- ☐ God's approval is steady.
- ☐ Most people are focused on their own lives.
- ☐ Kind people are around me.
- ☐ I can face others with honesty.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Proverbs 29:25**
  "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high."
- ☐ **Psalm 118:6**
  "The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?"

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Imagined and actual: Each week, write one thing you imagined people thought and what they actually said or did.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Psalm 118:6 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord is on my side, so I do not have to fear what others think.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Fear" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Check the evidence. List what people have actually said or done since the job loss.
- [ ] Reach out to one kind person. Contact someone who has been supportive and tell them what you are facing.
- [ ] Practice a simple answer. Write one honest sentence for "What are you doing now?"
- [ ] Pray Psalm 118:6. Read it aloud before a hard conversation.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Others must think I'm useless": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A kind response
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Others must think I'm useless.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You see me as I am. When I fear what others think, steady me with Your approval. Help me answer honestly and receive kindness from the people You send. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #29 · JOB LOSS AND SETBACKS

“I should be further along by now.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Comparison is a quiet thief. Classmates’ promotions, social media updates, a parent’s expectations, or an internal timeline we set long ago can make us feel behind. Setbacks, caregiving, health, or career changes can slow us down, yet we measure ourselves against a straight line that few people actually walk.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says that to everything there is a season and a time for every purpose under heaven. David prays, “My times are in Your hands.” Paul wrote, “Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize of God’s heavenly calling in Christ Jesus.” He also says that He who began a good work in us will carry it on to completion. God works on His own timetable, and the Bible’s heroes, from Moses to Joseph, often seemed far behind before God moved. Being “behind” is a measurement by the wrong ruler.

> *“Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize of God’s heavenly calling in Christ Jesus”* (Philippians 3:13–14).

Also see

> “To everything there is a season, and a time for every purpose under heaven” (Ecclesiastes 3:1).

> “My times are in Your hands; deliver me from my enemies and from those who pursue me” (Psalm 31:15).

> “For the vision awaits an appointed time; it testifies of the end and does not lie. Though it lingers, wait for it, since it will surely come and will not delay” (Habakkuk 2:3).

> “Being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus” (Philippians 1:6).

Common self-statements

- Everyone my age is ahead of me.
- I have wasted so much time.
- I should have achieved more by now.
- It is too late to catch up.
- I am behind in every area.
- I will never reach where others are.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I should be at a certain place by a certain age.
- Social comparison: Measuring my life against other people’s highlights.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I am either on schedule or a failure.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking what I have accomplished.

Challenging questions

- Who set the timeline I am measuring myself against?
- What have I accomplished and learned in the years I think were “wasted”?
- Whose path am I comparing myself to, and what do I not know about it?
- What does God’s timing look like in the lives of people in Scripture?
- What season am I in right now?
- What is one step forward I can take?

Truth summary

> My times are in God’s hands. The timeline I am measuring against is not His. I can look at where I have been, receive where I am, and press on toward what is ahead without condemning myself for the pace.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Plans
- Trust
- Thankful
- Dissatisfaction
- Will of God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Trouble/Hardship

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Do It Again — Steven Curtis Chapman
God’s repeated gifts and new mercies express His continuing love.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ’s resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Already There — Casting Crowns
God’s perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God’s steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I should be further along by now"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I should be further along by now." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who set my timeline?
- ☐ What have I learned in these years?
- ☐ Whose life am I comparing mine to?
- ☐ What season am I in?
- ☐ What can I thank God for?
- ☐ What is one step this month?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My times are in God's hands.
- ☐ There is a season for everything.
- ☐ Comparison is an unreliable ruler.
- ☐ I have grown more than I realize.
- ☐ God carries His work to completion.
- ☐ I can press on from here.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Philippians 3:13–14**
  "Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize of God's heavenly calling in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ **Ecclesiastes 3:1**
  "To everything there is a season, and a time for every purpose under heaven."
- ☐ **Psalm 31:15**
  "My times are in Your hands; deliver me from my enemies and from those who pursue me."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Where I am, not where I should be: Each week, write one thing you have learned or gained in this season and one step you took.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Philippians 3:13–14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "My times are in God's hands, so I can press on from where I am.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Plans" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Name the timeline. Write where you thought you should be and who or what set that target.
- ☐ Write your growth list. List what you have learned or become in the last five years.
- ☐ Limit comparisons. Take a break from checking others' updates for a week.
- ☐ Choose a next step. Decide on one forward move this month.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I should be further along by now": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Progress noticed
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I should be further along by now.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, my times are in Your hands. Forgive me for measuring myself by a timeline You did not give. Help me press on from where I am with thankfulness and trust. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #30 · JOB LOSS AND SETBACKS

“One setback means I've ruined my life.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

A single event, such as a failed business, a layoff, a lost promotion, or a bad financial decision, can feel like proof that everything is ruined. This is especially strong when we have worked hard to avoid mistakes. Perfectionism, a family that punished failure, or a past experience in which one mistake had large consequences can make every setback feel final.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him. Joseph told his brothers that what they intended for evil, God intended for good. Paul says we are persecuted but not forsaken, struck down but not destroyed. God said, “Do not call to mind the former things,” and “Behold, I am about to do something new.” These verses do not call a setback good. They say that it is not the last word, and that God can bring something out of it that we cannot yet see.

> *“And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose”* (Romans 8:28).

Also see

> “As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people” (Genesis 50:20).

> “‘Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.’” (Isaiah 43:18–19).

> “Persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed” (2 Corinthians 4:9).

> “Do not gloat over me, my enemy! Though I have fallen, I will arise; though I sit in darkness, the LORD will be my light” (Micah 7:8).

Common self-statements

- I ruined everything.
- There is no coming back from this.
- My whole life is wrecked.
- I blew my one chance.
- Everything I built is gone.
- One mistake has defined me.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Turning one event into total ruin.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing life as either perfect or ruined.
- Overgeneralizing: Treating one setback as a pattern for my whole life.
- Mental filter: Seeing only the damage and missing what remains.

Challenging questions

- What exactly was lost, and what is still here?
- Has anyone I admire had a major setback and gone on to good things?
- What did I learn that I could not have learned another way?
- What parts of my life are untouched by this?
- What might God be doing that I cannot yet see?
- What is one thing I can rebuild first?

Truth summary

> A setback is real, but it is not my whole life. God can work through hard things, and nothing is wasted in His hands. I can grieve what was lost, keep what remains, and begin again.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Hardship
- Hopeless
- Suffering
- Trust
- Plans

Godly Counsel Lessons:

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- Trouble/Hardship
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Even If — MercyMe
Trust in God need not depend on receiving the particular miracle we want.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
This classic gospel hymn celebrates Christ's rescue and the hope of life with Him.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "One setback means I've ruined my life"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

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Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"One setback means I've ruined my life." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What was lost and what remains?
- ☐ What did I learn?
- ☐ What parts of my life are untouched?
- ☐ Who has come back from a setback?
- ☐ What is one thing to rebuild first?
- ☐ Where am I catastrophizing?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ A setback is not a ruined life.
- ☐ God works all things together for good.
- ☐ I can begin again.
- ☐ What remains is worth building on.
- ☐ I do not have to see the whole plan.
- ☐ One chapter is not the whole book.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Romans 8:28**
  "And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose."
- ☐ **Genesis 50:20**
  "As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people."
- ☐ **Isaiah 43:18–19**
  "'Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

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PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Lost and left: Each week, list one thing lost and one thing that remains. Notice how the lists compare.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 8:28 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God works all things together for good, so this setback is not the end of my story.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
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6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

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- [ ] Make two lists. Write what was lost and what remains. Include people, skills, faith, and health.
- [ ] Name what you learned. Write two lessons you can take forward.
- [ ] Choose one thing to rebuild. Pick one area and take one small action this week.
- [ ] Share the story. Tell a trusted friend what happened and what you hope to do next.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "One setback means I've ruined my life": _____ % My truth: _____ %

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My song journal

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Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~One setback means I've ruined my life.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, this setback feels huge. Remind me that it is not the end of my story. Work in this for good, show me what remains, and give me courage to begin again. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.